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200 Wins, Two Coaches, One Culture

After 200 wins and a 2020 state title, Erik Vanags and Jeff Hinebaugh step away from Mariemont boys soccer together. (dek option)

By Chase Beach

Plain = Chase **"Quotes"** = Erik, Jeff, Luke, Quinn *Blue italic = Claude* Yellow = gap for Chase
454 words so far, not counting gaps · Claude's share: 139 words (31%), falls as gaps are filled · Target 700 to 900

On August 20, Mariemont beat Ross 6-0. It was Erik Vanags's 200th win as head coach, the most in Mariemont boys soccer history. Your sentence on how Erik found out. He didn't know until Lisa told him: "My wife reminded me... she made sure to get a picture of Jeff and I." *This fall is also his last on the sideline, and Jeff Hinebaugh's.*

200 is an extremely hard number to get to as a head coach in boys high school soccer. *The Ohio High School Athletic Association doesn't even track it. Its record book starts at 250 wins, and only 36 coaches in state history have made it. Vanags reached 209 with a win over CHCA. He has been head coach since 2011 and led the Warriors to an undefeated 23-0 Division III state championship in 2020. He was named Ohio's coach of the year in 2015 and 2020.* One sentence on how Erik reacts to being compared to Tom Crosby (215 wins) and Steve Peterson (203). He called them "freaking legends in the game" and said, "I don't look at us as in that pantheon."

A transition into Jeff, in your words: Erik won't talk about a win without him. "Everybody always calls me the head coach," Erik said. "I'm like, Jeff's been a part of every decision." *Jeff has coached with the program for 23 years without taking a salary,* and Erik asked me not to call him a volunteer. "Volunteer, you think, oh, it's part time," he said. "The day we lose at the end of the season, that night we're together planning the next season." Jeff is a selfless, happy go lucky guy. Always encouraging and never negative, very similar to Erik. Optional: the Continental Pirates story, or "One of the best parts is you get to work with your best friend."

Your bridge to the heart of it: it was never really about the wins. "We'd love to tell you it's winning," Erik said. "It's really not." Jeff said what he'll remember is "you see these guys coming in as freshmen, and you watch them come up through. And when they leave, they're great young men." You start working with kids as freshmen, and you teach them and coach them and watch them become leaders. And in 20 years together, Jeff said, "I have never heard him talk about any kid as a kid he doesn't like." Erik put it this way: "If you build the culture and you build the relationships, the success comes as a result of that."

Luke Brothers, who scored twice in the 2020 state final, still remembers what Erik told the team after it. "I always remember Erik, after the 2020 state win, saying, 'Don't let this be the defining point of your life,'" Brothers said. "I carry that with me for every new accomplishment or milestone." Optional: one sentence of yours on why that line matters, or let it stand.

One short paragraph, your connection. I'll never forget, on the first day of school, he talked in what seemed to be an Irish/Scottish accent. History class. I knew it was going to be very entertaining. He told me that every year he says he's not going to do it but ends up doing it. Optional final line of this paragraph: this is your first byline, 129 behind your mom, who has written for the Town Crier since 1999.

Quinn Budig, who Quinn is, e.g. "a 20XX graduate who played for both" *said their* "greatest impact has been in shaping them into men of character off it." Optional: the fuller quote: "Their passion for the game and belief in every athlete have helped countless players succeed on the field, but their greatest impact has been in shaping them into men of character off it."

One or two sentences on what's next: Jeff says he'll stay involved with Mariemont soccer "just not as a coach." Erik's teaching career is winding down too.

When I asked Erik what he would say to every player he has coached, he said, "I love ya, and I hope you're doing well."

Open before Sunday

- **Erik:** closing quote confirmed by Erik (Oct 30). Still to confirm: the program record, the 2011 start, and whether he's OK with "his last on the sideline" as worded. Don't use "goodbye for now" (Chase, Oct 30).
- **Tom Nerl:** email sent Oct 30, asking for the program record, previous record holder, first season and a quote.
- **Community voice:** Luke Brothers replied Oct 30 (in the draft; full quote in `interview/quote-bank.md`). Quinn Budig replied (in the draft; full quote in the quote bank).
- **Photos:** 06, 21 and 09 from Lisa (`photos/lisa-vanags.md`).